CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

FOOD TRUCK OWNER IN THE AI ERA

No salary exists behind this title. There is a truck payment, a commissary bill, and whatever profit survives both — for the average established truck, about $21–31K a year.

★ TL;DR — NO. No owner median exists at any source, so this card's figure is labelled for what it is: the Food Service Managers anchor, $69,390 (BLS, May 2025) — an EMPLOYEE median, not owner income. The owner arithmetic (IBISWorld-derived): average truck revenue ~$346K at a 6.8% profit margin leaves a profit pool of ~$21–31K for an established truck, before debt service — against $50K–$200K of launch capital and a mandatory permit stack. The roadmap below is the low-capital route into the same business. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$69K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

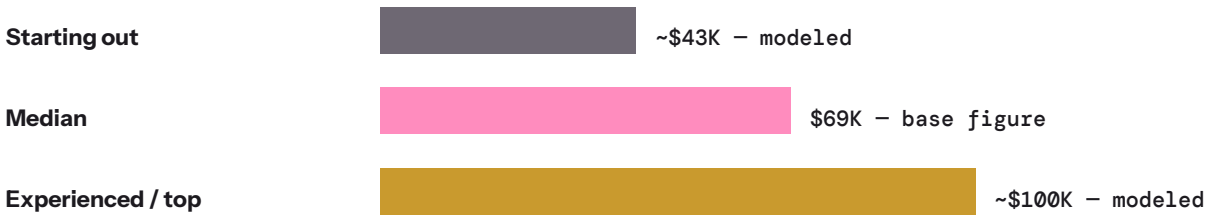
- Fails as a start because: the beginner commits $50K–$200K and clears a multi-permit, commissary-gated launch to reach a seat whose verified profit pool is ~$21–31K — while the $69,390 employee anchor requires no capital at all.

- Year-one reality: new trucks gross roughly $8–15K a month while building a base (industry compilations), which at a 6–9% margin is a few hundred to ~$1,300 a month of business profit — against fixed loan payments. Take-home near zero is a normal first year.

- Not an AI story: no robot cooks or sells from a truck (chain fry robots don't serve this segment). The tolls are platforms — DoorDash takes 15/25/30% and Uber Eats 20/25/30% on delivery orders, against food margins of 3–8%.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Food Truck Owner is a ~$69K median (compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A FOOD TRUCK OWNER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Cook and serve from the truck, daily, in all weather
- ✓ Permits, commissary runs, water, waste, propane, parking — the unglamorous half
- ✓ Chase locations, events and catering bookings; your following is your dining room
- ✓ Carry the loan, the insurance and the breakdowns personally

Think: a restaurant that pays rent to a commissary, rent to a lender, and rent to the apps — and keeps what's left, if anything is.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
None serving this segment. Miso Robotics' Flippy is a large-chain install (14 White Castle units) and its maker targets chains, not independents. The ghost-kitchen collapse (Kitchen United shut down Dec 2023; Reef/Wendy's wound down) is the cautionary tale: delivery-only models died on platform fees plus no owned customer relationship.	The food, the pitch at the window, the catering relationships, the judgment about where to park on a rainy Tuesday — the entire demand engine is the owner's own presence and following.

⚠ **Kill the folklore first: '90% of restaurants fail in the first year' traces to an American Express ad, not data. The verified numbers are bad enough — Parsa et al. (Cornell, 2005): 26.2% of restaurants closed or changed ownership in year 1 and 59.7% by year 3; BLS Business Employment Dynamics: ~85.3% of food-service establishments survive year 1 and ~59.3% reach year 5. And you cannot legally sell one meal without the permit stack: business licence, mobile food facility permit after plan review and inspection, a signed commissary agreement the permit itself requires, fire sign-off, seller's permit — repeated per county.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ The destination can work: established owner-operators who work the truck keep their own labour value on top of profit ✓ Testing the concept first is cheap: pop-ups, markets and catering need no truck loan ✓ Catering and events — the high-margin work — are open to you before any truck exists	✗ Capital first, income maybe: $50K–$200K to launch, personally guaranteed ✗ Year-one take-home is typically near zero to low while debt service is fixed ✗ Chase delivery and the apps take 15–30% of orders priced on 3–8% margins

Good fit? You have a tested concept, a following, and the discipline to prove demand before borrowing for the vehicle.
Bad fit? The truck IS the plan — buy it and figure out demand after the loan starts.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Caterer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager
The only owner-flavoured entry in this batch that is legally openable in year one without buying a vehicle: a catering business needs its permit stack (food-facility permit, commissary agreement, plan review) — passable gates, priced in hundreds-to-thousands, not a truck loan. You can be hired into catering work immediately at the cook layer while the business builds. Labelled anchor: Food Service Managers $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year. First move: sell three small events from a rented commissary kitchen and let the profit — not a lender — judge the concept.	The salaried version of running a food operation: median $69,390, +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, reached by a printed ladder (floor ~$35K → supervisor $45,370 → manager) inside BLS's 'less than 5 years' experience requirement. It teaches the exact skills a truck tests — costing, staffing, permits, P&L; — on an employer's capital. First move: two years on a chain or group ladder, running numbers you will later bet your own money on.

Smart move: Prove the menu before you finance the metal. A concept that cannot sell out a market stall or a catered event will not be saved by a $100K truck — it will be buried by one.
Where you land after: You land owning demand first and assets second: a catering book or a manager's P&L; record — and a truck, if it still makes sense, bought by a business that already exists.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	TEST THE	PICK YOUR	BUILD THE	PASS THE	BUY THE

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Do the IBISWorld-derived math yourself: ~$346K average revenue × 6.8% margin a $21–31K profit pool, before debt
- Price a real launch from industry guides: $50K–$200K, plus commissary at $500–$2,000 a month

STEP 2 — Test the concept without the truck

MONTHS 1-3

- Sell at markets, pop-ups and catered events from a rented commissary kitchen
- Track true margin per event after food, labour, kitchen rent and platform fees

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 3

- Door A if the concept sells: formalise the catering business (permits, commissary agreement, insurance)
- Door B if the numbers are thin: take the salaried ladder and keep testing on weekends

STEP 4 — Build the demand engine

MONTHS 3-9

- A following, a catering client list and two anchor locations/events that reorder — this is the asset a truck monetises
- Keep walk-up and catering revenue primary; treat app delivery as advertising, not income

STEP 5 — Pass the permit stack on paper first

MONTHS 6-9

- Map your counties' mobile food facility rules, plan review and commissary requirements before any purchase
- Get the food handler and food protection manager certifications your jurisdictions require

STEP 6 — Buy the truck only when the math orders it

YEAR 1-2

- The trigger: booked demand you are turning away, at margins that cover payment, commissary and a repair reserve
- If that trigger never fires, you own a profitable catering business instead of a depreciating truck — a win, not a delay

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

 Today: run the margin arithmetic on one real truck listing — price, payment, commissary, insurance.

 Days 1–30: concept on sale at a market or pop-up; true per-event margin tracked.

 Days 31–60: door chosen; catering permits researched county by county.

□ Days 61–90: three paid events done, with the profit — not the applause — recorded.

□ Day 90: you own evidence about your concept's demand, purchased for hundreds instead of a six-figure loan.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ DEMAND FIRST. TRUCK LATER. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. labor-market data (this title has no separate BLS occupation; the figure is a market/anchor estimate)). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.